

Q I want to continue breast-feeding, but I'm struggling. Is it really worth persevering?

Breast-feeding is time consuming, tiring, and, in some circumstances, leads to physical discomfort. For these reasons, it's not uncommon for mothers to reach a point where they are unsure if they can continue.

Like many new moms, you may be surprised at the demands of breast-feeding. After all, unless you have started to express milk, you are the only one that can feed your baby. It's natural to want to share the feeding and consider putting your baby on formula, mainly so that you can have a break and a night of uninterrupted sleep while your partner bottle-feeds the baby.

Give it time

Rest assured, though, that once you have settled into breast-feeding, it becomes easier. Your baby will nurse more efficiently, meaning that feedings are likely to be shorter and less time consuming. You will also, hopefully, have overcome initial breast-feeding discomforts (see pp.274–75). Don't forget, rather than using formula you can also begin to express your milk (see p.272), which can give you a break while ensuring your baby is still getting all the benefits of breast milk.

Reaping the rewards

Most women who persevere with breast-feeding are incredibly glad they did as they reach the stage when breast-feeding becomes a real joy—convenient, easy, and a wonderful bonding experience. So yes, it is worth persevering because breast-feeding can be such a mutually rewarding experience. But if you really feel that breast-feeding isn't for you, there is no shame in giving it up.

For many women **breast-feeding becomes pleasurable**, which more than compensates for any initial difficulties.



Feeding with ease In time most women settle into breast-feeding and find it mutually rewarding.

Q Will introducing a bottle of formula for one of our baby's feedings affect my milk supply?

It depends on when you decide to do this.

Giving your baby a bottle of formula allows you the occasional break and your partner a chance to feed your baby, and perhaps to help with night feeding. However, if you want to continue breast-feeding for a while, albeit on a reduced schedule, it's advisable to wait for about six to eight weeks before you introduce your baby to a bottle.

In the first few weeks, your breasts are adapting to feeding your baby and your milk supply is becoming established. If you introduce a bottle of formula, it might reduce your milk

supply, since it works on a supply and demand basis. Introducing a bottle and nipple also means that your baby has to learn a new sucking technique, which could lead to "nipple confusion" (see p.273).

After six to eight weeks, your milk supply will settle down and you can try to introduce a bottle. However, this will reduce the amount of breast milk you make, and it can be hard to reverse this decision, so be certain this is what you want to do before you introduce the formula.

It's also worthwhile to keep in mind that if you are hoping to have a break from night feedings, preparing a bottle of formula at night can be a lot more time-consuming than breast-feeding, and your partner may not be able or willing to do every nighttime feeding.



Did you know...

It is recommended that you breast-feed your baby exclusively until you start introducing solid food at about six months. This means only giving your baby breast milk—no other food or drink until then. Once you start solids, you can continue to breast-feed and use your breast milk to prepare foods. It is quite common for women who return to work to continue to breast-feed or combine breast-feeding with formula. Expressed milk can be given to your baby by the person taking care of her.